



COVER
STORY

PARTNERS IN CRIME

Jinnah was successful in exploiting the blunders of Gandhi and Nehru

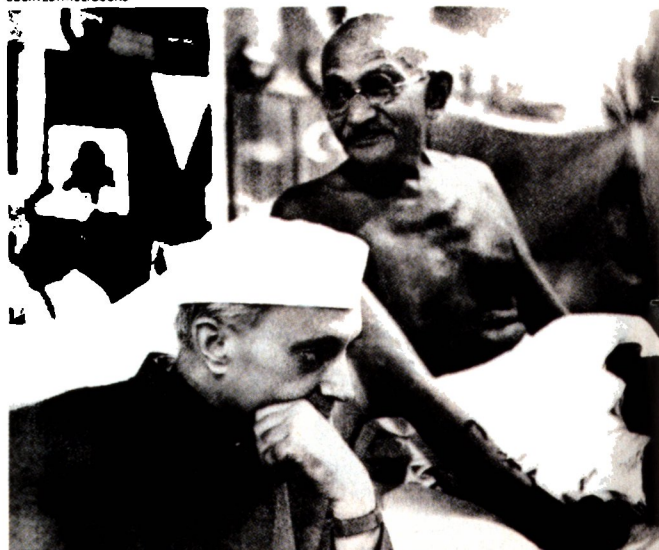
■ By YUVRAJ KRISHAN

The biggest piece of evidence being cited by those out to defend Jinnah and sell him as a symbol of Hindu-Muslim unity and secularism is his August 11, 1947 speech before the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan in which he said: "Everyone of you, no matter to what community he belongs, no matter what is his colour, caste or creed is first, second and last a citizen of this State with equal rights, privileges and obligations, there will be no end to the progress you will make. You are free to go to your temples, you are free to go to your mosques. Your caste, creed and religion has nothing to do with the business of the State." To come to a firm conclusion one has to closely observe and match Jinnah's actions and statements before and after this speech and its content. Jinnah repeatedly stressed on various occasions before and after his August 11 speech that Pakistan was a Muslim state, even going to the extent of saying that a Muslim state has to be based on Islamic Sharia. All this is recorded in the form of his speeches and letters. In November 1945, he wrote to the Pir Sahib of Manki Sharif in NWFP: "The Constituent Assembly of Pakistan would be able to enact laws for Muslims which won't be inconsistent with the Sharia laws and Muslims will no longer be obliged to abide by un-Islamic laws." Addressing the students of Edwardes College, Peshawar on April 18, 1948, he said: "What more can one expect that this mighty land has now been brought under a rule which is Islamic, Muslim rule, as a sovereign independent state." At the Muslim League Council in Karachi on December 14, 1947 he said: "Let it be clear that Pakistan is going to be a Muslim State based on Islamic ideals. It was not going to be an ecclesiastical state." Addressing the Karachi Bar Association on January 25, 1948, he said that the people who were rejecting the idea of an Islamic state were indulging in mischief and reiterated that the constitution of Pakistan would be based on the Sharia.

But the role of Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru who allowed Jinnah to succeed in his mission by their blunders and Muslim ap-

Nationalist Muslim leaders like Abul Kalam Azad and Mehmoood Hussain Madani opposed Pakistan as they felt that partition would affect Muslim domination in the region.

COURTESY: ROLI BOOKS



JAWAHARLAL NEHRU WITH MAHATMA GANDHI

peasement is also sought to be pushed under the carpet. There is ample evidence now to prove that nationalist Muslims like Abul Kalam Azad and the then Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind president Mehmoood Hussain Madani opposed Pakistan only because they felt that partition would affect Muslim domination in the subcontinent and Muslims would heavily lose. Plus they tried to extract a heavy price from the Congress for their patriotism in the name of minority protection. Congress leaders have tried to hide the fact that as Congress president in 1945, Azad even went to the extent of floating a proposal of rotating Indian headship. It meant India would have a Hindu and then a Muslim head of state and army chief by turns. So, eventually Gandhi and Nehru

made Congress a hostage to 'Hindu-Muslim unity at any cost' which Jinnah skilfully exploited and got more concessions from the Congress to establish parity in numbers between Hindu and Muslim representation.

As told to Uday Mahurkar

Yuvraj Krishan is a retired bureaucrat and the author of Understanding Partition.

